

ACADEMIC WRITING

Problem-Solution Essays

Structure, Strategy & Practice

OVERVIEW

What Is a Problem-Solution Essay?

A **problem-solution essay** identifies a real-world problem, explains why it matters, and proposes one or more practical solutions.

- Focuses on **current, relevant issues** that affect people
- Requires the writer to **analyze causes and effects**
- Proposes **realistic, actionable** solutions
- Convinces readers that the solutions **can work**

STRUCTURE

The Four-Part Framework

Introduction

Hook · Connecting Information · Thesis



Why the Problem Is Important

Evidence · Impact · Significance



Solution(s)

One solution — or two with a transition between them



Conclusion

Restate thesis · Call to action

PARAGRAPH 1

The Introduction

Hook

Background information or history of the problem — grabs the reader's attention

Connecting Information

Bridges the hook to the thesis — explains the context and narrows the focus

Thesis Statement

States the problem clearly and signals that a solution (or solutions) will be proposed

PARAGRAPH 2

Why the Problem Is Important

Before proposing solutions, the writer must convince the reader that **the problem is worth solving**.

- Explain **who is affected** and how
- Provide **facts, statistics, or examples** to show the scale of the problem
- Describe **consequences** of leaving the problem unsolved
- Build urgency — make the reader **care**

One Solution or Two?

One Solution

- 1 Introduction
- 2 Why the Problem Is Important
- 3 The Solution
- 4 Conclusion

Two or More Solutions

- 1 Introduction
- 2 Why the Problem Is Important
- 3 **Solution 1**
Include a transition to Solution 2
- 4 **Solution 2**
- 5 Conclusion

Transitioning Between Solutions

When presenting two solutions, the **end of Solution 1's paragraph** must connect smoothly to Solution 2.

- **Acknowledge** Solution 1's value before introducing Solution 2
- Use phrases like *"In addition to..."* or *"Another solution is..."*
- Signal a **shift in focus** without dismissing the first idea
- Keep both solutions **equally developed** in length and detail

Writing the Conclusion

- **Restate the thesis** in new words — remind the reader of the problem and the proposed solution(s)
- Summarize the **key points** without introducing new information
- End with a **call to action** — encourage readers or decision-makers to act
- Leave the reader with a **memorable final thought**

EXAMPLE

Putting It Into Practice

Topic: Homeschooling — Quality Control

WHY IS THIS PROBLEM IMPORTANT?

Educators want to be sure that a homeschooling curriculum covers the same information as traditional curricula.

SOLUTION 1

Create a list of required content that homeschooled children must learn.

SOLUTION 2

Require training for homeschool parents to ensure that content is delivered according to standards.

SUMMARY

Key Tips for Success

CHOOSE A REAL PROBLEM

Pick a topic that affects real people and has **practical, realistic solutions** you can argue for.

HOOK YOUR READER

Open with an engaging fact, story, or question that makes the **problem feel urgent**.

PROVE THE PROBLEM FIRST

Don't jump straight to solutions — spend a full paragraph **establishing why the problem matters**.

BE SPECIFIC

Vague solutions are unconvincing. Use **concrete details** to show exactly how each solution would work.